PSYCHOLOGICAL APPEALS

Advertisers use psychological appeals directed to basic human needs. Abraham Maslow, the American humanist psychologist who developed a hierarchy of needs in the 1960s, theorized that all humans have needs that must be met to achieve self-fulfillment. The most basic are the physiological needs, such as food, water, and shelter. People also need basic feelings: feelings of security, belonging, and being loved, as well as feelings of self-esteem. The final need is self-actualization, the highest form of self-fulfillment. Advertisements may focus on any one or a combination of these needs.

Psychological appeals in advertising influence the emotional component of people's attitudes. The advertised product is associated with positive emotions such as fun, love, belonging, warmth, excitement, and satisfaction. Advertisements can also be based on fear, as when advertisers try to convince consumers that there will be negative consequences if they do not buy their product, focusing on the need for safety. For example, buying any tire other than the one advertised will increase the risk of an automobile accident. Advertisements also appeal to the human need for self-esteem, which is heightened through power and success. An ad may aim to associate the product with the consumer being the best or having the most.

CLASSIC CONDITIONING

Russian physiologist Ivan Petrovich Pavlov discovered the process of classical, or Pavlovian, conditioning in the early twentieth century. An unconditioned stimulus (US) naturally produces an unconditioned response (UR). For example, the image of a baby may naturally produce pleasant, even maternal or paternal, feelings. In classical conditioning, the unconditioned stimulus is paired with a neutral stimulus (NS), one that does not normally produce the unconditioned response. For example, a can of soda (NS) can be paired with a picture of a baby (US). With several pairings, the neutral stimulus will become the conditioned stimulus (CS), eliciting the unconditioned response without the actual association with the unconditioned stimulus. Once conditioning occurs, the unconditioned response becomes the conditioned response (CR). Thus, the can of soda becomes the conditioned stimulus when it alone produces pleasant feelings (CR).